

SharePoint Online: Confluence-Style Project Documentation Setup Guide

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This guide provides a complete, step-by-step, copy-paste friendly procedure to configure **SharePoint Online** as a highly effective project documentation platform — mirroring the structure and usability of **Confluence Cloud**. Every section includes exact navigation paths, annotated screenshots, and ready-to-use content blocks.

Phase 1: Establish the Information Architecture

The foundation of a Confluence-style experience in SharePoint relies on a clear separation between **Site Pages** (for content) and **Document Libraries** (for files). Before creating any content, the site structure must be designed intentionally.

Step 1.1 — Create a Dedicated Communication Site

For project documentation, a **Communication Site** is preferred over a Team Site. It provides a cleaner, wider reading layout and does not create an unnecessary Microsoft 365 Group.

Navigation Path: SharePoint Home → + Create site → Communication site

1. Open your SharePoint tenant home page: `https://[your-tenant].sharepoint.com`
2. Click **+ create site** in the top-left corner.
3. When prompted, select **Communication site**.
4. Choose the **Topic** design template.
5. Enter the site name using this naming convention: `[Project Code] - Documentation` (*Example: Project Phoenix - Documentation*)

6. Enter a brief description (1–2 sentences about the project).
7. Click **Finish**.

Copy-paste ready site name format: `[Project Code] - Documentation`

 SharePoint Create Site Screen

Step 1.2 — Create Structured Document Libraries

Instead of storing all files in the default “Documents” library, create purpose-specific libraries. This mirrors Confluence’s attachment organisation by space section.

Navigation Path: Site → Settings (Gear icon) → Site contents → **+ New** → Document library

Create the following five libraries in order:

Library Name	Purpose
01_Requirements	Business and functional requirements documents
02_Design	Architecture diagrams, wireframes, design specs
03_Testing	Test plans, test cases, UAT sign-off sheets
04_Deployment	Runbooks, release notes, infrastructure configs
99_Reference	Third-party docs, vendor materials, standards

For each library:

1. Click **+ New** → **Document library**.
2. Enter the library name exactly as shown above.
3. Click **Create**.

 Create Document Library

Phase 2: Design the Home Page (The “Space Overview”)

Your Home page replaces the Confluence left navigation panel and space overview. It must serve as the definitive entry point for all stakeholders.

Step 2.1 — Edit the Home Page

Navigation Path: Site Home → **Edit** (top-right corner)

1. Navigate to the Home page of your new site.
 2. Click **Edit** in the top-right corner.
 3. Remove any default web parts that are not needed (e.g., Events, default News).
 4. You will now build the page from scratch using the steps below.
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Step 2.2 — Add the Project Overview Text Block

1. Click the **+** icon to insert a new web part.
2. Select **Text**.
3. **Copy and paste** the following template into the text web part, then update the bracketed fields:

PROJECT OVERVIEW

Project Name: [Project Name]
Purpose: [2-3 sentence description of the project goal]
Status: [Active / On Hold / Completed]
Timeline: [Start Date] - [End Date]
Project Owner: [Full Name, Email]
Tech Lead: [Full Name, Email]
Last Updated: [Date]

Step 2.3 — Add the “Quick Links” Navigation Panel

This web part acts as the Confluence left-sidebar navigation, providing one-click access to all major documentation sections.

Navigation Path: Edit page → + → Quick Links

1. Click + to add a new web part.
2. Search for and select **Quick Links**.
3. In the web part settings panel (right side), change the layout to **List**.
4. Click + **Add links** and add the following links (you will create these pages in Phase 3):

Link Label	Target Page
Home	Site Home
Project Overview	/SitePages/Project-Overview.aspx
Requirements	/SitePages/Requirements.aspx
Architecture & Design	/SitePages/Architecture.aspx
Developer Guide	/SitePages/Developer-Guide.aspx
Testing & QA	/SitePages/Testing-QA.aspx
Deployment & Operations	/SitePages/Deployment.aspx
Decisions (ADRs)	/SitePages/ADR-Log.aspx
FAQ / Knowledge Base	/SitePages/FAQ.aspx

Quick Links Web Part

1. Click **Republish** when done.
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Phase 3: Create Core Documentation Pages

Each page below mirrors a Confluence page in a project space. Follow this pattern for every page: **create** → **structure** → **link from Home**.

Step 3.1 — Create a New Site Page

Navigation Path: Site → + New → Site Page

1. From any page, click + **New** in the top navigation bar.
2. Select **Site Page**.
3. Give the page a clear, searchable name using this convention:

Naming Convention: *[Section] - [Topic]* Examples: *Architecture - High Level*, *API - Authentication*, *ADR - Database Selection*

1. Add the appropriate content using the templates below.
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Step 3.2 — Copy-Paste Page Templates

Use these templates by pasting them into the **Text** web part on each page.

Requirements Page Template

REQUIREMENTS

Document ID: REQ-[Number]
Version: [1.0]
Status: [Draft / Approved / Deprecated]
Owner: [Name]
Last Reviewed: [Date]

BUSINESS OBJECTIVE

[Describe the business need this requirement addresses.]

FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS

1. [Requirement 1]
2. [Requirement 2]
3. [Requirement 3]

NON-FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS

- Performance: [e.g., Response time < 2 seconds]
- Security: [e.g., Role-based access control required]
- Availability: [e.g., 99.9% uptime SLA]

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- [] [Criterion 1]
- [] [Criterion 2]

RELATED DOCUMENTS

- [Link to Design Doc]
- [Link to Test Plan]

Architecture Decision Record (ADR) Template

ARCHITECTURE DECISION RECORD

ADR ID: ADR-[Number]
Title: ADR - [Decision Name]
Status: [Proposed / Accepted / Deprecated / Superseded]
Date: [YYYY-MM-DD]
Author: [Name]

CONTEXT

[Describe the situation and the problem that required a decision.]

DECISION

[State the decision that was made clearly and concisely.]

OPTIONS CONSIDERED

Option A: [Name]

- Pros: [...]
- Cons: [...]

Option B: [Name]

- Pros: [...]
- Cons: [...]

RATIONALE

[Explain why this option was chosen over the others.]

IMPACT

[Describe the consequences: technical, financial, timeline, team.]

SUPERSEDED BY (if applicable)

[Link to newer ADR if this one is deprecated]

How-To / Guideline Page Template

HOW-TO GUIDE

Guide Title: [Title]
Audience: [Developers / QA / Operations / All]
Complexity: [Beginner / Intermediate / Advanced]
Owner: [Name]
Last Updated: [Date]

PURPOSE

[One paragraph explaining what this guide helps the reader accomplish.]

PRE-REQUISITES

- [Access / tool / knowledge required]
- [Access / tool / knowledge required]

STEP-BY-STEP PROCEDURE

Step 1: [Action]
→ [Expected result]

Step 2: [Action]
→ [Expected result]

Step 3: [Action]
→ [Expected result]

TROUBLESHOOTING

Issue: [Common problem]
Solution: [How to fix it]

RELATED PAGES

- [Link to related doc]

Meeting Notes Template

MEETING NOTES

Meeting Title: [Title]
Date & Time: [YYYY-MM-DD, HH:MM]
Location: [Teams / Room / Call]
Facilitator: [Name]
Note-taker: [Name]
Attendees: [Name 1, Name 2, Name 3]

AGENDA

1. [Topic 1]
2. [Topic 2]
3. [Topic 3]

DISCUSSION SUMMARY

[Topic 1]: [Summary of what was discussed]
[Topic 2]: [Summary of what was discussed]

DECISIONS MADE

- [Decision 1]
- [Decision 2]

ACTION ITEMS

#	Action	Owner	Due Date	Status
1	[Action]	[Name]	[Date]	Open
2	[Action]	[Name]	[Date]	Open

NEXT MEETING

Date: [YYYY-MM-DD]

Step 3.3 — Save a Page as a Template

Once you have created and formatted a page, save it as a reusable template so all team members can use it.

Navigation Path: Page in Edit mode → Page details (right panel) → **Save as template**

1. Open the page you want to save as a template.
2. Click **Edit**.
3. In the right-hand panel, click **Page details**.
4. Scroll down and click **Save as template**.
5. The template will now appear when any team member clicks **+ New** → **Site Page**.



Phase 4: Configure Versioning and Metadata

Step 4.1 — Enable Version History on Site Pages

Navigation Path: Site contents → Site Pages → Library settings → Versioning settings

1. Go to **Settings** (Gear icon) → **Site contents**.
2. Click **Site Pages**.
3. Click the **Gear icon** → **Library settings** → **More library settings**.
4. Click **Versioning settings**.
5. Under **Document Version History**, select:
 - **Create major versions:** Yes
 - **Keep the following number of major versions:** 50
6. Click **OK**.



Best Practice: Always add a brief change summary at the top of a page when making significant edits. Use the format: **[Date] – [Your Name]: [What changed]**

Step 4.2 — Add Metadata Columns to Document Libraries

Navigation Path: Document Library → + Add column → Choice

For each document library, add the following metadata columns:

Column Name	Type	Choices
Document Type	Choice	Requirement, Design, Runbook, Test Plan, API Spec
Module / System	Choice	[Your project's modules]
Audience	Choice	Business, Development, Operations, All
Status	Choice	Draft, In Review, Approved, Deprecated

To add each column:

1. Open the document library.
2. Click + Add column (far right of the column headers).
3. Select **Choice**.
4. Enter the column name and choices as listed above.
5. Click **Save**.



Metadata Columns

Phase 5: Configure Access and Permissions

Step 5.1 — Assign Users to Permission Groups

Navigation Path: Settings (Gear icon) → Site permissions → Share site

SharePoint has three default permission groups. Use them as follows:

Group	Permission Level	Who to Add
Site Owners	Full Control	Project Manager, Tech Lead, Documentation Owner
Site Members	Edit	Developers, QA Engineers, Business Analysts, Scrum Master
Site Visitors	Read Only	Business Stakeholders, Executives, Auditors

To add a user:

1. Click the **Gear icon** → **Site permissions**.
2. Click **Share site**.
3. Enter the user's name or email.
4. Select the appropriate permission group from the dropdown.
5. Optionally uncheck "Send email" if you prefer to notify them manually.
6. Click **Add**.

 Site Permissions

Important: Avoid setting page-level or library-level permissions unless absolutely required for sensitive content. Group-level permissions are far easier to manage.

Phase 6: Integrate with Microsoft Teams

Connecting your SharePoint site to Microsoft Teams ensures the documentation is always one click away during daily work.

Step 6.1 — Pin the SharePoint Home Page as a Teams Tab

1. Open your project's **Microsoft Teams channel**.
2. Click the **+** icon next to the channel tabs at the top.
3. Search for and select **SharePoint**.
4. Choose **Add a page from any SharePoint site**.
5. Paste the URL of your documentation Home page.

6. Name the tab (e.g., “Project Docs”).

7. Click **Save**.

Step 6.2 — Post the Documentation Link in the Channel

Copy and paste this announcement message into your Teams channel:

 Project Documentation Hub is now live!

All project documentation, requirements, design decisions, and runbooks are now centralised in our SharePoint site:

 [Paste your SharePoint site URL here]

Quick links:

 Requirements → [URL]

 Architecture → [URL]

 Developer Guide → [URL]

 ADR Log → [URL]

Please bookmark this site and use it as your primary reference.
Questions? Contact [Project Owner Name].

Phase 7: Enforce Documentation Culture

Tools alone do not create good documentation. The following rules must be agreed upon by the team and enforced during sprint ceremonies.

Rule	How to Enforce
No feature is complete without a documentation page	Add “Documentation Updated” as a Definition of Done item
Every page must have a named owner	Add an “Owner” field to every page template
Review and update docs during Sprint Review	Add a “Docs Review” agenda item to Sprint Review
Outdated pages must be clearly labelled	Add [DEPRECATED] to the page title and a notice at the top
Old projects must be archived	Move completed project sites to a dedicated “Archive” hub

Quick-Start Checklist for New Projects

Use this checklist every time a new project documentation site is created.

SHAREPOINT PROJECT DOCUMENTATION – SETUP CHECKLIST

SITE SETUP

- [] Create Communication Site named "[Project Code] – Documentation"
- [] Delete default unnecessary web parts from Home page
- [] Add Quick Links navigation web part to Home page
- [] Add Project Overview text block to Home page

DOCUMENT LIBRARIES

- [] Create 01_Requirements library
- [] Create 02_Design library
- [] Create 03_Testing library
- [] Create 04_Deployment library
- [] Create 99_Reference library
- [] Add metadata columns (Document Type, Audience, Status) to each library

PAGES

- [] Create and publish: Project Overview page
- [] Create and publish: Requirements page
- [] Create and publish: Architecture & Design page
- [] Create and publish: Developer Guide page
- [] Create and publish: Testing & QA page
- [] Create and publish: Deployment & Operations page
- [] Create and publish: ADR Log page
- [] Create and publish: FAQ / Knowledge Base page
- [] Save ADR, Requirements, and Meeting Notes pages as Templates

VERSIONING & GOVERNANCE

- [] Enable major version history on Site Pages library (keep 50 versions)
- [] Enable major version history on all Document Libraries

PERMISSIONS

- [] Add Project Manager and Tech Lead to Site Owners
- [] Add project team (devs, QA, BAs) to Site Members
- [] Add stakeholders and business users to Site Visitors

MICROSOFT TEAMS INTEGRATION

- [] Pin SharePoint Home page as a tab in the project Teams channel
- [] Post documentation hub announcement in Teams channel

Completed by: _____ Date: _____

This guide was prepared for internal use by AINQA Internal. For questions or updates, contact the project documentation owner.